

MY GRANDFATHER WAS AT TEUTOBURG

He was eight years old. Hiding in a tree. He watched Varus's men march into the forest.

He told me: they sang. They sang the whole way in.

Three legions. That was us. We did the thing Rome said could not be done. We thought that was the end of it.

Then Germanicus came back. He did not come to fight. He came to make sure we understood what victory costs. He burned the longhouses. The grain stores. The grandfathers who had hidden in trees.

He left. Said we were pacified.

Arminius died in a ditch with his brother's knife in him. Rome paid for that knife. Gold is how they fight when legions fail.

My grandfather lived long enough to hang this shield.

He did not live long enough to see what came after.

The Cherusci are gone now. There are men with our blood out there, somewhere, with Roman names.

I held up three fingers for the legions we buried.

I should have held up more for what it cost us.